

shapes and such. A chart would probably be the right choice when there is a distinct trend, or if you want to emphasise a trend. Talking about charts, assume the audience doesn't know where to look, even if it's somewhat obvious. Embellish it with arrows and other shapes.

Sound and video and...

Use these judiciously. We mean, put some thought into it—don't just slap on a sound and/or video clip. *Where* you insert a video clip is of the essence. As regards sound clips, it's definitely an art: you could have music looping throughout the presentation, and you could have “bang!” sounds when certain bulleted points come in, all without looking silly—if you pull it off well. If you don't, people will laugh at you, behind your back or otherwise. It's that delicate.

With animation, too, there's limitless potential for abuse. You can use it well, or you can ruin your presentation with it. One concrete thing we can tell you is that it should be relevant or meaningful—so no Clippit (or any cousin of Clippit that you might come across or even design). On the other hand, bulleted points sliding in can be a good idea.

Pretty much the same goes for slide transitions: there's potential for abuse. The rule of thumb here is as simple as it gets: use only one transition effect, or loop two at a maximum.

Photos must look professional

If they don't, you'll send out the message that your company can't afford good photography or a good photographer. Many a slide has been marred by low-res photographs. As we said in one rule above, what it looks like on your monitor might not be what it will look like on the screen. Check for this.

Rehearse!

None of the above rules were organised, but we'll end this section where it should end: by telling you that you must rehearse your presentation. But well, why should you?